

FAMILY COURT DATA REPORT · STATE SERIES · NO. 50

WEST VIRGINIA
WHAT FAMILIES ARE REPORTING.

Pulled from the Family Rights Registry — a cross-location dataset on what pro se parents are actually experiencing inside West Virginia's family courts and child-welfare system.

69

WEST VIRGINIA FAMILIES ON RECORD · 133 CHILDREN IMPACTED · 25 MONTHS MEDIAN MONTHS LOST OF PARENTING TIME

DATA AS OF
OCTOBER 15, 2026

COUNTIES REPRESENTED
33 OF 55

COMPILED BY
MEG · STANDWITHMEG.COM

01 NAMED COURT ACTORS · WEST VIRGINIA

A name appears below only after 3 or more independent families have named the same actor in West Virginia. Submitter names, emails, and contact details are never published. Comments below are direct family reports — one per family — with all identifying information removed.

Judge Richard Witt

JUDGE · PUTNAM COUNTY · **3 SUBMISSIONS**

> *"Said that if I had an attorney, I probably would not have lost my kids."*

> *"Friends with my exes father, along with ruling against me for 12 years."*

> *"Told me if I spoke he would make sure I never seen my children again"*

Create Complaint Packet: https://my.standwithmeg.com/reports/actors/wv-judge-richard-witt/complaint-packet
Family-reported pattern context only. Each person must file only their own truthful, first-hand complaint using their own facts, dates, evidence, orders, transcripts, and documents.

01 NAMED COURT ACTORS, CONTINUED

Maggie Kuhl CONTINUED 1 / 2

ATTORNEY / GAL / CHILD REPRESENTATIVE · PUTNAM · **3 SUBMISSIONS**

> *"Maggie Kuhl works at Putnam County Courthouse multiple times during the week. She is also represented Cara Branham my ex for the majority of the court proceedings over the 11 years and the 22 times that she has sued me for contempt and there's only one twice both financial both because the other Party owes me $4000 and refuses to pay any of accrued cost on my side of the fence. Maggie Kuhl works at Putnam County Courthouse multiple times during the week. She is also represented Cara Branham my ex for the majority of the court proceedings over the 11 years and the 22 times that she has sued me for contempt and there's only one twice both financial both because the other Party owes me $4000 and refuses to pay any of accrued cost on my side of the fence. She also has violated professional codes of conduct like that is her main job with lying coming in right before court and filing something knowing that I'm representing myself and don't have time to respond going outside of the quart room with Joseph Hunter to then take my decision making away when I was representing myself so they had a closed-door discussion about who was going to have decision-making without me present, and I'm representing myself. She has tried to embarrass me at my workplace by having somebody come in, and serve me multiple times even though I have my cell phone number that hasn't changed for almost 17 years and stated the first time I was served at my workplace to call me and I will meet them anywhere to get the paperwork. They do not need to come to my employment and try to embarrass me at my employer. They still continue to do so"* PUTNAM COUNTY

> *"I have a special needs child. I was always 100% primary parent and that father never went to doc appts or therapy appts. that he never paid for food or diapers or anything. The father never spent anytime with the child. Then later I was told that she has "relations" with the petitioner's counsel. Maggie never opened her mouth in defense. she also said that she had never lost a case to the petitioner's attorney and made a lot of good proposes and then rolled over and did nothing during trial to protect the child. Even when I gave her alot of evidence to us"*

01 NAMED COURT ACTORS, CONTINUED

Maggie Kuhl CONTINUED 2 / 2

ATTORNEY / GAL / CHILD REPRESENTATIVE · PUTNAM · **3 SUBMISSIONS**

> *"At one point, she went over a year without speaking to the kids, yet continued to write reports and make recommendations."*

Create Complaint Packet: https://my.standwithmeg.com/reports/actors/wv-maggie-kuhl/complaint-packet
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Public threshold rule: Names are grouped conservatively by normalized spelling, role, and location. Common titles, punctuation, casing, and middle initials collapse together. Close misspellings are not auto-merged without admin review. Only family-direct submissions count toward the public threshold.

THE HEADLINE NUMBERS

WEST VIRGINIA AT A GLANCE.

Across 69 West Virginia families reporting through the Family Rights Registry, the patterns are consistent: long durations in court, serious financial loss, and a disproportionate number of parents going unrepresented because they ran out of money fighting.

CHILDREN IMPACTED
133
69 of 69 families reported child counts

MEDIAN FAMILY BURDEN
$110,880
median across 18 families reporting 3+ categories

MEDIAN MONTHS LOST
25
of parenting time

WENT PRO SE
47.8%
33 of 69 who answered; 20 of 69 ran out of money

SUBMISSIONS	AVG CHILDREN / FAMILY	FAMILIES REPORTING CHILDREN	COUNTIES REPRESENTED
69	1.9	69 of 69	33

WHY THIS REPORT EXISTS.

On January 29, 2024, I lost custody of all five of my children.

- NO TRIAL.
- NO QUESTIONING.
- NO SUBSTANTIATED ABUSE.

It took only a signature on an ex parte emergency order to erase a mother. I refused to disappear. I fought back, and built the Family Rights Registry so West Virginia families — and families across every represented location — would stop being invisible to the data. This report is their record.

— MEG · STANDWITHMEG.COM

03 THE COST OF WEST VIRGINIA FAMILY COURT

Legal fees are the largest reported expense, but they are not the only one. Lost wages, evaluation costs, and reunification services compound the financial loss — pushing most families toward pro se representation once their savings run out.

EXPENSE CATEGORY	RESPONSES	MEDIAN	MEAN	TOTAL REPORTED
Attorney Fees	36	$8,250	$30,882	$1,111,766
Lost Wages	25	$3,000	$38,449	$961,230
Other Court Fees	17	$0	$3,222	$54,770
Therapy / Evaluations	25	$2,000	$4,623	$115,582
Reunification Services	19	$500	$2,795	$53,103
GAL Fees	22	$950	$4,155	$91,401
Asset Loss [1]	24	$27,500	—	—
Median Family Burden (18 families reporting 3+ categories)	—	**$110,880**	—	—

Median vs. mean: Median is the middle reported amount, so it better reflects the typical reporting family when a few very large expenses appear. Mean is the average across reporting families and can be pulled higher by outliers. **Median Family Burden** is the median of total reported expenses across families who reported costs in 3 or more expense categories with a combined total of at least $1,000 — a true median of real family totals, restricted to families who filled out enough of the financial section to characterize their case and excluding obvious data-entry artifacts.

1. On asset loss: One respondent reported an extreme outlier that skews the mean beyond usefulness. We report the median ($27,500) and suppress the mean and total, pending data-quality review. Lost Wages also contains wide variance; median is the honest headline.

LOST PARENTING TIME · MONTHS



04 WHO IS REPORTING · WEST VIRGINIA

Most families documenting in West Virginia are currently active in, or recently closed out of, long-running cases. Nearly half have lost all contact with their children. Percentages below use only families who answered that specific topic.

CASE STATUS · SYSTEM AFFECTED

CASE STATUS

Active case: stuck or delayed	33	48%
Case closed: more than 2 years ago	13	19%
Case closed: within last 2 years	9	13%
Active case: progress being made	5	7%
Not provided	5	7%

SYSTEM AFFECTED

Both Family Court and CPS	35	51%
Family Court Only	17	25%
CPS Only	15	22%
Unknown	2	3%

DURATION · CUSTODY OUTCOMES

TIME IN SYSTEM

1 – 3 years	19	28%
3 – 5 years	15	22%
5 – 10 years	12	18%
6 months – 1 year	9	13%
Less than 6 months	8	12%

CUSTODY STATUS

Visitation Only	20	29%
No Contact / Total Loss of Access	14	20%
Adopted Out (Rights Terminated)	13	19%
Children in Foster Care	11	16%
Full Custody	6	9%

GEOGRAPHY · ALLEGATIONS REPORTED

TOP COUNTIES

Kanawha	6	10%
Mason	6	10%
Wood	6	10%
Putnam	4	6%
Cabell	4	6%
Monongalia	3	5%

TOP ALLEGATIONS REPORTED

Family Court False Accusations (Domestic Violence/Abuse/Alienation)	23	34%
False Accusations CPS (Non-Medical) (Vengeful ex-partner, malicious report)	21	31%
High Conflict Divorce	7	10%
Other	6	9%
Medical CPS (Medical Child Abuse allegations, disagreement with doctors)	4	6%

05 PARENT VOICES — WEST VIRGINIA

Selected voice excerpts appear here for readability. Every approved, shareable West Virginia comment is printed in full in the appendix that follows.

> *The system has destroyed my family. I've lost one child to adoption who should've never been adopted out two of my kids. I signed over to their father in fear that I would lose them, and then I lost a pregnancy due to stress of the court, and then I got protected by two other [...]*
>
> — SABRINA

ON THE REPORTED ALLEGATIONS

Destroyed my entire family. My now adult children have problems from enduring this trauma. My marriage failed because of this. I lost custody of my youngest 2 children to my ex husband, with the assistance of him paying off CPS workers to take my children with no investigation [...]

— WEST VIRGINIA PARENT · AMANDA

MORE VOICES FROM WEST VIRGINIA

Destroyed my children and allowed them to be abused physically and mentally

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

An abusive narcissist was able to rip my children away from me by claiming parental alienation after years of emotional, mental and legal abuse.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

The family court has completely destroyed my family. I have been robbed of the right to motherhood and all access to my children over false allegations and abusive systematic procedures.

— JESSI

Traumatized us my children have been medically neglected and abused since being is state care

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

The system sealed and silenced us while stripping all of us of our rights and innocence, not just the children.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Family court proved that abuse can be rewarded and those who never abuse their kids can be punished. As soon as my children were ordered into the full custody of their father, opposing counsel sent an email offering to return the children if I obtained a "do not prosecute" to [...]

— CRISTY

05 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED

> *The systems has stole my children's life as my children as me as a good contract mother yrs. They stole our life of church God with my children by assaults retolerations after trying to protect myself and family . Our lives are destroyed by the courts fraud abussive litigations [...]*
>
> — INCA

Cps has done nothing but tear my family apart for years. I have severe ptsd and anxiety so badly. My children do too. My youngest child now suffers from an eating disorder. I just want her back home. I will never stop fighting for her.

— CONNIE

Separated and divided the family and alienated me from my kids

— DANIEL

DESTROYED CHILDRENS CHILDHOOD,13 FOSTER HOMES ,AND SEPORATED Boys.DEEPLY HURT WHOLE FAMILY,WE WILL NEVER LOOK AT FAMILY COURT THE SAME THEY ARE SAVAGES!

— GAIL

The system has completely DESTROYED my family. I feel like I have no purpose to live anymore.

— AMBER

The system has destroyed relationships, legacies, holidays, milestones, but it has cost me a beautiful relationship with my sons, one that I had with my father, and he had with his father, and it will affect both of these young men for the rest of their lifetime. I'm not a [...]

— BRANDON

Lied put whatever in reports cussed me n kids n gets by with it

— TAMMY

This system has ripped apart my family, cost me my business, sanity and ruined my boys childhoods.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Wayne County court ordered no contact based on a GAL report written most like while GAL was intoxicated. She is currently in rehab for alcohol and another GAL has not been assigned for months. Judge accused me of giving my daughter an abortion bill and said "no matter what you [...]

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05 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED

> *Judge Jim Douglas fails children in WV. He allows personal relationships to cloud his judgment. He failed these children. He alienated them from a good father and family.*
>
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The system has failed to see the true abuser

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

It ripped my daughters away because my daughter got with a girl at school (a trouble maker) who told her to do this and she could do whatever she wanted. They took my daughters away from me who was my everything. Now I have nothing. I want to give up.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

The system has wrecked my life no doubt but more importantly my children's lives and their futures. These kids are affected for the rest of their lives and will prob never be able to fully trust anyone again. The struggle they've been facing trying to understand why they were [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

They put my son through unnecessary stress

— TRACEY

There was no investigation, only an initial contact with CPS alleging educational neglect, in regards to missing 3rd grade assessment. I explained this was our 3rd grade year and assessment is due by June 30 2026. Heard nothing else from CPS. 3.5 months later sheriff serves me [...]

— MISTI

The system has destroyed my family. They couldn't care less about my daughter. They knew I was unable to fork out all the money I needed to to get proper legal representation.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Ruined my life not only my kids but mine after my mom was killed 25 years ago by my stepdad

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Has literally taken my very life

— RACHEL

05 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED

> *Ripped my identity of being a MOTHER and turned me into a ghost to my children when I'm all they ever known.! Separated all my children breaking our soul tied bonds.! Took a piece a paper of lies to erase DNA .!*
>
> — ANONYMOUS PARENT

They have not only stolen my sense of self but they've robbed me and my husband of creating a bond with our newborn. They have shattered my daughters (6 yr old) trust and emotional health.

— CHELSEA

They have taken my Heart, my soul, my love, my life and stomped it into hell on earth.

— T

Ruined my life health spirit. I am dead inside

— DANIELLE

They have traumatized us, villainized us, and caused us an extreme amount of emotional and mental anguish, while putting me over $40,000 in credit debt. Took away my precious parenting time and my daughters teen years that we will never get back.

— HEATHER

Broken our home, our hearts, our trust in the system. Taken precious time that I will never get back with my child.

— NICOLE

West Virginia Courts are renowned for their corruption -- my case is no different. You can see more here: https://thefamilycourtfiles.substack.com/p/post-11-a-financial-control-narrative

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Sydneys mission was to terminate my rights from the beginning of the case, she wouldn't communicate with me about court dates visits much less answer my call. She completed her mission by adopting out my daughter but my son was not.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Made-up accusations to gain custudy,many fees such as drug testing,child transport visits,many more

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

05 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED

> *Complete loss of access to my daughter. Detrimental affect on my daughters mental health*
>
> — ANONYMOUS PARENT

Has treated us unfairly treat us like we're criminals without reading the facts just make stuff up and they believe it they told my 3 grandchildren that we didn't want or love you hem because they fart this is not even close to the truth

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Torn my family apart. Given me no hope. Cause emotional damage to my son and myself.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

The system has taken over 5% of my childs life with him that I will never get back during a time when his mother needs him the most.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

It completely tore my world apart and made me have no hope in the justice system/government!

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

The court system that says God as our witnesses allowed a criminal lawyer defend criminals in family court. The psychological harm and reputation is forever dipped in hell and I'll gladly give up my ticket to upstairs to meet them at its gate in the Gods Court

— KAYLA

It has cost me everything. My child, the innocence of my child. Our bond. My motherhood. A child's childhood. It has cost me my mental health even further, my ability to trust "justice" and "authority". It has cost me my home, finances, a nest egg my deceased father left me [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

I have a few quotes: “The greatest injustice isn't losing in court. It's watching a parent-child bond slowly disappear while the system calls it due process.” “Family court didn't just decide my case. It decided how much of my children's childhood I would miss.” “When the system [...]

— TIMOTHY

They've caused my children to constantly check that I'm home with them, my oldest still has separation anxiety & my youngest was too young to understand. My oldest worries constantly that a stranger can come into our home & take him at any given moment for any kind of reason [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

47 West Virginia parents submitted approved, shareable comments. 44 selected excerpts appear here; the full comments begin on the next page.

06 FULL PARENT COMMENTS — WEST VIRGINIA

The comments below are the full approved, publicly shareable survey comments from West Virginia families. Data-only and do-not-share submissions are excluded from this public appendix.

> The system has destroyed my family. I've lost one child to adoption who should've never been adopted out two of my kids. I signed over to their father in fear that I would lose them, and then I lost a pregnancy due to stress of the court, and then I got protected by two other states whenever I gave birth to my other two children so altogether, I have six children and two are in my custody that the state couldn't touch because they did leave their jurisdiction to try and take them and got told where to go by two other states who read their case that was closed and told them they had no reason to touch my firstborn son. Let alone be there trying to take my new babies, and I have to custody of two of my kids, but I don't know how to get my older son out of adoption. I've looked at the case, and I've seen all the broken laws and constitutional rights that were broken and my parental rights that were stepped all over but mind you in the same case the judge decided to adopt three children to a registered sex offender knowing he was a registered sex offender and I have confirmed he is on a registry so let that sit in a judge says that a mother isn't good enough to be a parent in the eyes of the state, no matter how many hoops she jumped through, but believes that a registered sex offender who touched a child under the age of 13 is suitable enough to raise three children let that set in
>
> — SABRINA

> Destroyed my children and allowed them to be abused physically and mentally
>
> — ANONYMOUS PARENT

> An abusive narcissist was able to rip my children away from me by claiming parental alienation after years of emotional, mental and legal abuse.
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> Destroyed my entire family. My now adult children have problems from enduring this trauma. My marriage failed because of this. I lost custody of my youngest 2 children to my ex husband, with the assistance of him paying off CPS workers to take my children with no investigation or evidence. Now my youngest 2 boys are without their mother during their teenage years.
>
> — AMANDA

06 FULL PARENT COMMENTS, CONTINUED

> Traumatized us my children have been medically neglected and abused since being is state care
>
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> The system sealed and silenced us while stripping all of us of our rights and innocence, not just the children.
>
> — ANONYMOUS PARENT

> Family court proved that abuse can be rewarded and those who never abuse their kids can be punished. As soon as my children were ordered into the full custody of their father, opposing counsel sent an email offering to return the children if I obtained a “do not prosecute” to spare the father from the fallout of his crimes. Unable to get that, the smear campaign continued and I am still without my children. The theory of parental alienation is being misused and weaponized in true, substantiated abuse cases. I lost complete faith in our legal system.
>
> — CRISTY

> The systems has stole my children's life as my children as me as a good contract mother yrs. They stole our life of church God with my children by assaults retolerations after trying to protect myself and family . Our lives are destroyed by the courts fraud abussive litigations Satan cruelty retolerations for money .
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— GAIL

The system has completely DESTROYED my family. I feel like I have no purpose to live anymore.

— AMBER

The system has destroyed relationships, legacies, holidays, milestones, but it has cost me a beautiful relationship with my sons, one that I had with my father, and he had with his father, and it will affect both of these young men for the rest of their lifetime. I'm not a perfect man, and I have made mistakes and I have reacted to some situations that I have been put in in not the best way, but I have never jeopardize my son safety I have always thought about the best interest of my son's future, their financial longevity, their success in business and in relationships and family and growth. I've went from a hero to a zero on the sidelines cheering, my son, being a part of every minute to being ripped away like a villain, no arrest, The physical and Dangerman just false allegations, small town good old boy, clubs, and manipulation by a system. That is the biggest Ponzi scheme money making garbage I've ever had the disgust to experience in my 38 years on this earth. This place is where dreams go to die!!

— BRANDON

Lied put whatever in reports cussed me n kids n gets by with it

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The system has wrecked my life no doubt but more importantly my children's lives and their futures. These kids are affected for the rest of their lives and will prob never be able to fully trust anyone again. The struggle they've been facing trying to understand why they were taken from their loving home and been allowed 0 contact with their mother since has done unimaginable irreversible damage and pain to these innocent babies and their parents. This corrupt system lies everyday to every one of us, starting with them stating that they are "for the kids". They are for no child, they're for their pockets and that is all. Thats the truth and it is horrifying.

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— TRACEY

06 FULL PARENT COMMENTS, CONTINUED

There was no investigation, only an initial contact with CPS alleging educational neglect, in regards to missing 3rd grade assessment. I explained this was our 3rd grade year and assessment is due by June 30 2026. Heard nothing else from CPS. 3.5 months later sheriff serves me notice to appear in court. After taking son to GAL meeting he was removed on "imminent danger" allegations. FALSIFYING RECORDS

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> — KAYLA

> It has cost me everything. My child, the innocence of my child. Our bond. My motherhood. A child's childhood. It has cost me my mental health even further, my ability to trust "justice" and "authority". It has cost me my home, finances, a nest egg my deceased father left me which was for me and my future children to thrive. My dignity, my spirit, I am a shell of who I once was. It has almost cost me my job due to overwhelm. The court has allowed domestic abuse to thrive, while my entire life has been torn part. My life has been deduced to before this.. and after this.. My child reported sexual abuse, my mental health was targeted, and the abusers go without remorse, they thrive off my dime and have used a scared little girl in their disgusting pawn to further destroy me, while they destroy her. They have taken EVERYTHING from me.
>
> — ANONYMOUS PARENT

06 FULL PARENT COMMENTS, CONTINUED

I have a few quotes: “The greatest injustice isn’t losing in court. It’s watching a parent-child bond slowly disappear while the system calls it due process.” “Family court didn’t just decide my case. It decided how much of my children’s childhood I would miss.” “When the system fails to recognize parental alienation, it doesn’t punish a parent. It punishes a child.” “Justice delayed in family court isn’t measured in months. It’s measured in birthdays, holidays, and memories that can never be replaced.” “No parent should have to fight harder to see their child than to protect them.” “This isn’t a website about revenge. It’s a record of what happens when a system loses sight of the children it was created to protect.”

— TIMOTHY

They've caused my children to constantly check that I'm home with them, my oldest still has separation anxiety & my youngest was too young to understand. My oldest worries constantly that a stranger can come into our home & take him at any given moment for any kind of reason they come up with & he struggles with that to this day

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

My ex and I own a business and without any evidence presented of any wrongdoing on my behalf, the judge removed me from my business and has not allowed me to earn a living from my business that is still operating. She also denied me spousal support and has left me penniless and forced me into bankruptcy. And continues most hearings to drag this out even further. And she also threatened to put me in jail for six months if I ran my own business.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Because the court is aware of mother's past the child did not receive fair representation or due process in proceedings. Total neglect if childs education and learning disabilities

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Neither attorney acknowledged that my son is specials needs bc father doesnt want him labeled. son is almost 3 and non verbal. court gave father 50/50 custody and he does not attend doc appts or therapy and cannot communicate with child. child does not get proper hygiene with the father and father repeatedly reports to me that child refuses to eat or drink on his time.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

47 full approved West Virginia comments are included in this appendix.

07 HOW TO READ THIS REPORT

WHAT THIS IS

The Family Rights Registry is a public, parent-reported data collection run by Stand With Meg. Every figure in this West Virginia report comes from West Virginia respondents who voluntarily submitted survey entries about their experience inside family court and/or CPS.

This report is built to help families, advocates, reporters, and legislators see the patterns emerging in West Virginia — not to replace formal research, and not to name individual judges or counties as responsible parties.

WHAT IT ISN'T

This is not a representative sample. Respondents self-select. The 69 West Virginia families reporting here are not the universe of West Virginia families in court — they are the families who found the survey, trusted it enough to submit, and told us what happened to them.

Financial figures are self-reported. Response counts and percentages use the number of families who answered that specific topic or financial field. The Median Family Burden headline is the median of total reported expenses across families who reported in three or more expense categories. Quotes are minimally edited.

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Data in this report was collected April 2024 – October 2026 through standwithmeg.com/family-rights-survey. Submissions are timestamped. Duplicate-submission heuristics use normalized email + location, with direct survey rows preferred over legacy rows and the newest row retained within each source. Categorical responses from multi-select and short-answer fields are normalized monthly.

Dollar fields exclude blank, negative, and obvious data-entry artifact values above the report's field caps. When asset-loss values contain a strong statistical outlier, the asset-loss mean and total are suppressed and only the median is reported. Lost-wage, attorney-fee, and asset-loss entries are self-reported and not corroborated against tax records or court filings.

Geographic reporting uses the county or regional field as submitted, with light normalization (e.g. "Butte silverbow" → "Butte–Silver Bow"). Quotes carry one of three public permission states: *Anonymous*, *First-name only*, or *Full attribution with consent to public use*. Court actor names appear only after 3 independent families name the same actor.

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ABOUT THIS REPORT

This report is based on self-reported survey submissions collected by Stand With Meg. Counts and categories reflect responses available at the time this packet was generated.

This report is for informational and advocacy use only, not legal advice or an official government record.

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